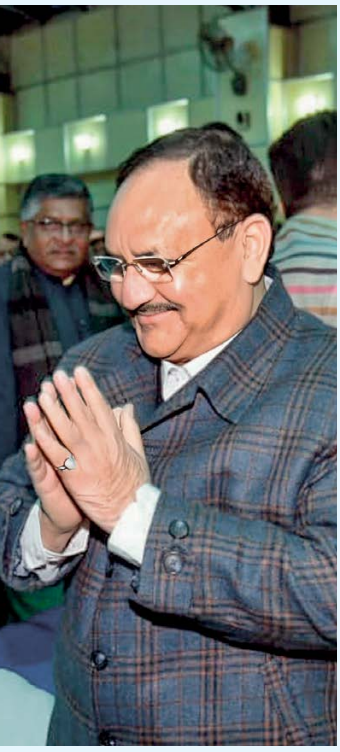
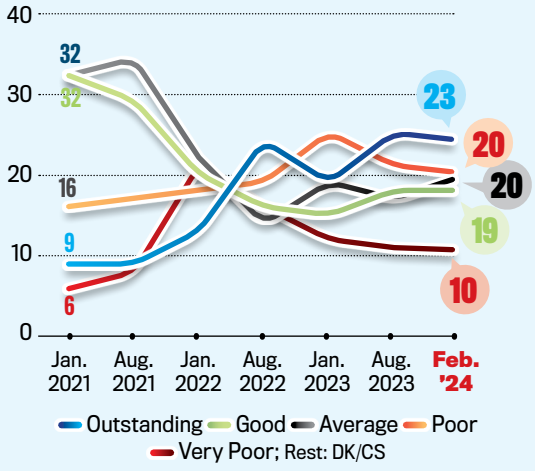


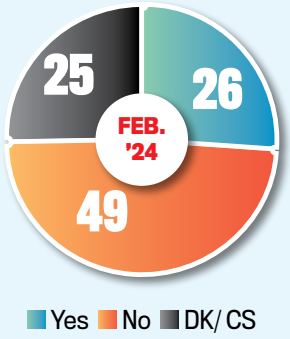
ANI

Q. How would you rate the performance of the Congress as an Opposition party?



The Congress party stays steady but does not do enough

Q. With Nitish's exit from the I.N.D.I.A. bloc, do you think the caste census issue will be put on the backburner?



The caste census is still a sensitive issue for many respondents

All figures in % and rounded off

the marginalised sections of society, be it farmers, daily- wagers or truckers. At other times, he's has given interviews to social media influencers who ask him about his education, food choices and personality quirks.

If he completed the 4,000-km-long Bharat Jodo Yatra (BJY)—a walkathon from Kanyakumari to Kashmir—between September 2022 and January 2023, now he has embarked on another such exercise, the BJNY, a bus ride from Manipur to Mumbai interspersed with walkathons and public rallies. If the focus of BJY was to spread the message of unity, the BJNY is a quest for social, economic and political justice. Unfortunately for Rahul and the Congress, the voters don't seem enchanted with this experiment at mass outreach. In the MOTN poll, 48 per cent of the respondents say Rahul's BJNY will not be a factor for them while casting their vote in the Lok Sabha election. More than a third of the respondents also believe the yatra will make no difference to the Congress performance in the coming election; 11 per cent see it as an image management drill for Rahul. When asked if their views about the politics and leadership of Rahul improved after BJNY, 42 per cent replied in the negative.

39
PER CENT
RATE RAHUL GANDHI'S PERFORMANCE AS AN OPPOSITION LEADER GOOD OR OUTSTANDING, DOWN FROM 52 PER CENT SIX MONTHS AGO

That Rahul has failed to catch the public imagination is also evident from the fact that the percentage of respondents who rate Rahul's performance as an Opposition leader as good or outstanding has come down from 52 six months ago to 39 now. Even though he remains the Congress's best bet to revive the party, the approval rating has seen a marginal dip—from 32 per cent in August 2023 to 31 per cent now. Similarly, the perception on the performance of the Congress party has also gone south, with 41 per cent of the respondents rating its performance as an Opposition party as outstanding or good, down from 43 per cent in the previous edition. But the biggest erosion has been for Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge. In August 2023, 47 per cent of the respondents felt he had put in an outstanding or good performance as party chief; only 36 per cent have the same opinion now. The only consolation for the Congress, perhaps, is that a majority of the respondents—44 per cent—blame Nitish for his U-turns as against 21 per cent holding the Grand Old Party responsible for the same.

The survey also breaks another myth. It was widely perceived that Nitish's shift to NDA will deprive the Opposition of one of its biggest poll planks against the BJP—the call for a caste count. It was Nitish who had provided